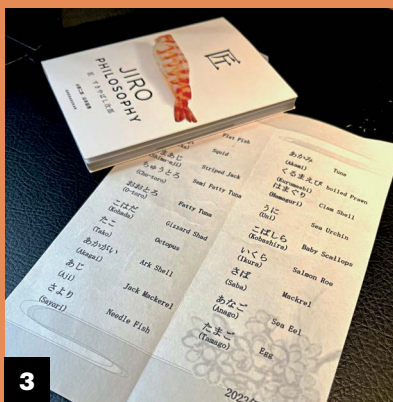


gestured that I should approach him. "Name?" he asked. I showed him my confirmation email and he nodded. "You wear perfume?" was the next question. Well, of course, I lied.

I took my seat by the counter at 12:02 pm and was handed the menu for the day. It had precisely 19 courses of *nigiri*; listing seafood such as Sea Eel, Fatty Tuna, Octopus, Mackerel, Baby Scallops, Needlefish, Squid and my personal favourite *Uni* (Sea Urchin). Sadly, Jiro Ono was not present in the restaurant; one of the English-speaking



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PHOTO BY GETTY IMAGES

- ① Jiro Ono (left) with former English footballer David Beckham during one of his visits to Sukiyabashi Jiro
- ② There are only 10 counter seats at the sushi restaurant
- ③ There is a set menu for the day, decided by the chef based on the day's catch
- ④ Jiro Ono (pictured) has trained his son Yoshikazu, who runs the restaurant now

chefs explained that because of his poor health, he only visits the restaurant intermittently. His eldest son, Yoshikazu Ono, a 64-year-old sushi master trained by Ono, has now assumed the responsibility.

Yoshikazu-san served each piece of *nigiri* to me in quick succession. As soon as the sushi was placed on my plate, he indicated that I should lift it with two fingers and put it in my mouth, without wasting precious seconds, to ensure it would touch my tongue at the perfect temperature. There was no small talk or background music in the restau-

rant, just delicious, serious food.

At 12:24 pm, I finished my last piece of *nigiri* and was served a Japanese sweet melon and bitter tea for dessert, while the cashier hurried with the bill. And that was it—22 minutes of the greatest sushi experience of my life.

Was it worth it? Yes, absolutely! Would I go back? No, it was one of those once-in-a-lifetime experiences that are sometimes so perfect that you are scared to go back. But I will remember the meal for ever. **BT**

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